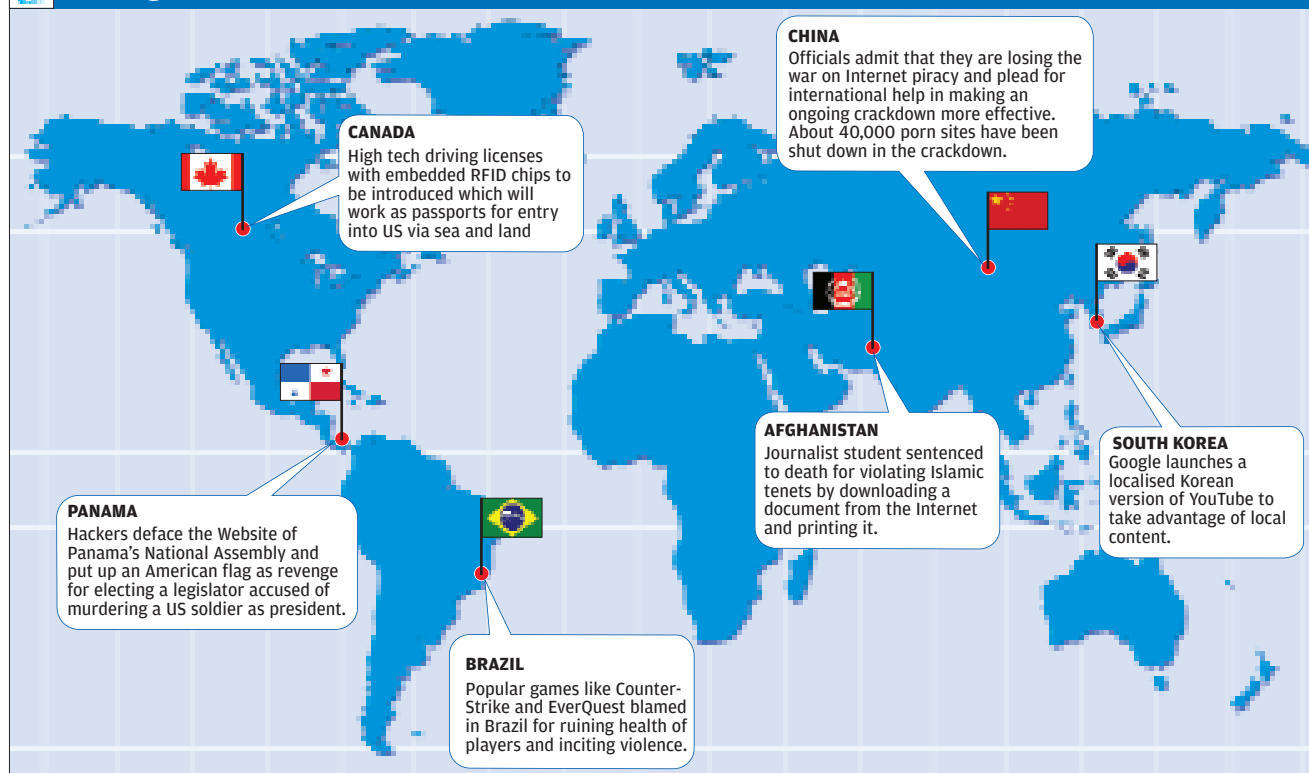




instructions at <http://tinyurl.com/3apmna>.

Users are complaining that the least that Microsoft could have done would be to set up a tutorial for circumventing the blocks on third-party file formats—as they did with their own products—or directed users to the correct source on the Internet.

IT'S IN THE EULA

My Spyware Community

More and more companies are monitoring user activity following an installation of their software. Reporting anonymous user statistics is considered all right if the user opts for the programme, but some companies want the user to opt for various programmes without knowing.

Sears, an American chain of departmental stores, recently launched a customer relationship

program called "My SHC Community." When customers provided their e-mail address to the company Web site or at the store, they would receive an e-mail inviting them to join the SHC community. The mail discloses that participants would have to download software on the computer that would track their surfing habits anonymously. What it does not mention, however, is that the program will log all the Web sites a user visits, along with the items he buys, will store all the data he enters on any Web site and track his online personal and health records.

There is no mention of this anywhere in the invite e-mail, and only a reference to this can be found when reading carefully through the End User Licence Agreement of the software to be installed; it occurs mid-way through a paragraph, without a heading or any bold lettering to inform users of the extent of monitoring.

When this was reported to Sears, vice president Rob

Harles claimed that SHC "goes to great lengths to describe the tracking aspect". Spyware expert Benjamin Edelman strongly disagrees.

In another such incident, Dan Moren, a blogger, found out that every time he used any Adobe CS3 product, an outside connection was made to 92.168.112.207.net. What's so strange about this is that though this looks like an internal IP address, it ends with ".net"—something no internal IP address does. If you look closely, the last group has the letter "O" instead of a zero. What this means is that your usage statistics *might* be reported to Adobe when you use any of the CS3 line of products. When this address is followed in a browser, it leads to Omniture, a large user statistics and analytics firm.

There is, however, a namesake opt-out procedure you can follow; to do so, you'll need to visit <http://tinyurl.com/29z3r8>. This page will install the opt-out

cookie on your computer. If you delete your cookies or use CS3 products from other accounts on your computer, you will have to repeat the opt-out process.

Users are not impressed, with many of them complaining that it would be much better if Adobe had mentioned to them that they were being monitored. As for Sears, most participants who came to know—from online reports—of this activity quickly uninstalled the software. Spy if you must—but with a little more class, please!

ALL IN ONE PLACE

Copy And Paste...

It could get annoying to set up a profile every time you create a new account on the Web. For example, social networking sites: you create an account, add friends, add photos, add interests, etc. and then you sign up at